
2026 Plan Making Workshop: University of Illinois' Department of Urban and Regional Planning

Title: Developing Holistic Housing Strategies and Project Funding for Rural, Downstate Communities

Project Description: Over the last six years, the Central Illinois Land Bank Authority has helped small, rural communities build a code enforcement foundation to address blight, pilot rehab programs, and focus on proactive housing preservation strategies. CILBA utilizes a data driven framework to pinpoint problems and raise grant funds to address them. The land bank expanded its geography significantly in 2025 and plans to continue growing in 2026 to address the unmet housing needs/challenges of rural communities downstate.

CILBA seeks to provide rural communities with flexible, holistic funding solutions to address blight and disinvestment. In order to obtain sustained project funding and implement best practices, CILBA proposes the following elements in a Spring 2026 *Plan Making Workshop*.

1. Finalize Actionable Member Workplans: finalize, map/visualize, and data analysis
2. State of Practice Survey for Comparative Member Analysis
3. Research and Policy Analysis

Proposed deliverables and Project Scope:

- 1) Member Workplans: finalize all workplans, project visualization (GIS mapping), and project prioritization. Site visits can be conducted to better understand implementation priorities.
- 2) Survey CILBA members and other selected communities
 - a. State of Practice survey to determine member baseline. How much is each community doing to address demolitions, rehabs, new construction, and commercial?
 - b. Code Enforcement staffing and approach – complaint driven system or proactive approach?
 - c. Local Implementation Funding: Tax Increment Financing, dedicated gaming revenues, Foundations/philanthropy, other
 - d. Economic Development/Jobs and Employer Housing Needs – where specifically is more housing necessary to sustain/attract more jobs?
- 3) Research and Policy analysis: summarize opportunities to implement Illinois' Housing Blueprint and build partnerships to sustain community development work across a large geographic region.
 - a. For new construction residential projects: how many permits pulled over last decade, what contractors/developers pulled permits, what size project built and sales prices?

Proposed timeline: Spring 2026 Semester

Desired student qualifications: this project is a great opportunity to demonstrate a broad array of skillsets needed to solve rural housing challenges. While mapping and data analysis are important skillsets, survey work will be another important skill to help small communities better develop “best practices” that do not involve much money. The project requires strong writing skills to frame policy analysis on rural community development funding.

For a completed work product, the goal is to provide a compelling policy analysis with real world examples which highlights the need for flexible funding to address the housing needs of rural downstate communities. The project should directly reference how this work aligns with Illinois’ Housing Blueprint.

Project resources

- Collaboration with the Executive Director and numerous Board members
- Attend two CILBA Board meetings with opportunity to present
- Access to CILBA’s Advisory Board and state Technical Assistance providers
- Two site visits to document needs/opportunities
- Possible material costs for final presentation